

Australia Daily Brief

Wednesday, September 16, 2026

2,113 words · 8 min read

RE: US delegation presses Canberra on Port of Darwin and defence spend · UK rejects China's AUKUS claims at IAEA · Bougainville mine attack turns deadly · NZ parliament passes India trade deal · Fiji declares HIV emergency

ASX 200

8,696

-2.41%

AUD/USD

0.7132

-1.23%

NZX 50

13,623

-1.42%

NZD/USD

0.5759

-1.47%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 A visiting US congressional delegation pressed Canberra to end the Chinese-owned Port of Darwin lease and lift defence spending, with Representative Michael McCaul warning that sending a nuclear submarine abroad unarmed is "kind of an unveiled threat."
- 2 Armed men burned machinery belonging to India's Lloyds Metals & Energy at the Panguna mine site in Bougainville on Sunday, killing at least one man in the ensuing shootout, and Papua New Guinea's trade minister says he had warned the company against investing there.
- 3 Fiji's Cabinet declared a national HIV emergency after prevalence rose from one adult in 167 five years ago to one in sixty today, with 2,060 new diagnoses recorded in 2025.

• TOP STORIES

US-AUSTRALIA

US congressman says unarmed submarines send an 'unveiled threat'

Visiting American politicians pressed the Australian government to end the Chinese-owned lease over the Port of Darwin and to ramp up defence spending. **Michael McCaul**, who chairs the Friends of Australia caucus in the US Congress, said US submarines in Australia could be armed with nuclear weapons: "It's kind of an unveiled threat to have a nuclear sub going around without any weapons." The delegation also warned that Chinese ownership of the port threatened cooperation on critical minerals.

per SMH: "US subs in Australia could be armed with nukes, says key Republican after visit" · also AFR: "US puts heat on Canberra over Port of Darwin, defence spending"

AUKUS

UK rejects China's 'false' AUKUS claims at the IAEA

Britain rejected Chinese claims about the AUKUS submarine program at the International Atomic Energy Agency as the dispute over the pact's nuclear safeguards escalated. The exchange moves a long-running argument about naval nuclear material and non-proliferation obligations into the IAEA's formal proceedings, where Beijing has pressed the case against the three partners. The report gives no detail on which specific claims London contested.

per The Australian: "UK blasts China's 'false' AUKUS claims as nuclear submarine row escalates"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Armed attack on Indian miner at Panguna ends in fatal shootout

Armed men entered the Panguna copper mine site on Sunday and set fire to machinery belonging to India's Lloyds Metals & Energy Ltd, whose staff were also reportedly attacked. At least one man was killed in the ensuing shootout and police have arrested up to several suspects; Bougainville police chief **Francis Tokura** said the group came from Buin in the south with high-powered weapons. PNG Trade Minister **Richard Maru** said he had repeatedly advised the company against investing, while ABG President **Ishmael Toroama** called the attack "terrorism."

per RNZ Pacific: "Panguna attack: PNG minister claims Indian miner was warned against investing in Bougainville"

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY

New Zealand parliament passes India trade deal

New Zealand's parliament passed legislation implementing a trade agreement with India that cuts tariffs on most exports. Bloomberg reported the same day that Wellington has cleared the path for the free-trade agreement, adding India to New Zealand's roster of trade partners seven weeks before the November 7 general election.

per Reuters: "New Zealand parliament passes India trade deal, cutting tariffs on most exports" · also Bloomberg: "New Zealand Clears Path for Free-Trade Agreement With India"

● OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Veterans say Australia is unfit for a UN Security Council seat · SMH Federal Politics

A group of veterans told Matthew Knott that Australia has let down vulnerable Afghans who worked alongside Australian forces and should not be rewarded with a seat on the UN Security Council. The intervention targets one of Canberra's declared multilateral ambitions and lands as the succession to the UN secretary-general moves into view.

AU-DEFENSE

Defence revives military satellite plan two years after \$7bn project axed · The Australian

The Department of Defence is reviving a military communications satellite program two years after **Richard Marles** cancelled a \$7 billion project. Sovereign military satellite communications was one

of the capabilities dropped in the earlier round of portfolio reprioritisation, and its return reopens a procurement the government had closed.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

[PNG's six-month gun amnesty ends with a disappointing haul](#) · ABC Pacific

Papua New Guinea's national gun amnesty and buyback program ended today, and from Thursday illegal possession of a firearm carries a possible life sentence under new laws. Enga provincial government media officer **Daniel Kumbon Jnr** blamed poor coordination and funding: "I was expecting more firearms to be given, and we'd have reached about 1,000 or so." The six-month drive targeted tribal violence in the Highlands ahead of next year's election.

AU-POLITICS

[Family visas for foreign students targeted in migration overhaul](#) · ABC Politics

The government will restrict family visas for international students as part of a migration overhaul, with **Tony Burke** fronting the changes. Doctors have warned against the family visa cuts, and the announcement follows One Nation's move to put student visa reductions at the centre of the migration argument.

AU-DEFENSE

[US confirms weapons in orbit, China warns of a space arms race](#) · ABC Politics

US Secretary of the Air Force **Troy Meink** said the United States has stationed weapons in orbit and is ready for "evolving threats," without detailing capabilities or timing. China warned the move risks turning space into a "battlefield" and an arms race. **Cassandra Steer** of the Australasian Centre for Space Governance at the ANU National Security College assessed the announcement for the ABC.

TRADE-ECONOMY

[China opens \\$15bn canal shortcut to Southeast Asia](#) · The Australian

China has opened a 134-kilometre canal costing at \$15 billion to cut shipping costs and deepen trade ties with Southeast Asia. The project lands while Washington and Canberra are pressing partners over Chinese-linked ports and logistics, including the Darwin lease raised by the visiting congressional delegation.

• STAT OF THE DAY

1 in 60

Fijian adults living with HIV

Prevalence has risen from one adult in 167 five years ago, prompting Cabinet to declare a national emergency.

RNZ Pacific

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLAR 2 · THE DIPLOMAT

[Pillar 2's record resists assessment for want of a metric](#)

The Diplomat argues Pillar II's progress has been difficult to judge "not due to a lack of activity, but because there's no agreed metric for what success should look like." Quantum technologies and advanced cyber remain the workstreams most visibly reported.

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

Fiji declares a national HIV emergency

Health Minister **Atonio Lalabalavu** declared a national HIV emergency in a recorded statement, backed by Prime Minister **Sitiveni Rabuka** and Cabinet. One adult in sixty now lives with HIV, against one in 167 five years ago, with 2,060 new diagnoses in 2025 and prevalence near two percent among women in antenatal care. The WHO ranks Fiji's epidemic the second fastest growing in the Asia-Pacific behind Papua New Guinea.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Solo Mara named Fiji's foreign affairs permanent secretary

Solo Mara has been appointed Permanent Secretary for Fiji's Ministry of Foreign Affairs and External Trade after completing the Public Service selection process. The appointment puts a new official at the top of Suva's foreign ministry as Fiji prepares to host a Pacific pre-COP in Nadi.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

Frost and drought wipe out highland food gardens in PNG

Freezing nights followed by intense sun have destroyed food gardens in Kosipe, in Central Province's Goilala district, where **Anthony Morant** said the frost falls nightly and "we're going into the fourth month now, and all the current crops are gone." Taro, sweet potato, bananas and sugar cane have been lost at Upper Mendi in the Southern Highlands. Australia's Bureau of Meteorology says Pacific Ocean temperatures could exceed the highest levels observed since reliable records began in 1950.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Police reinforcements sent to East Makira after arson

Police reinforcements have deployed to East Makira after homes, kitchens and a fuel depot were burnt down following sorcery accusations. The deployment stretches a constabulary already carrying provincial security tasks across scattered islands.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Wale urges Pacific states to convert climate research into action

Islands Business reports Solomon Islands Prime Minister **Mathew Wale** calling on Pacific countries to turn climate knowledge and research into practical action. The appeal comes as the region assembles its COP agenda and as El Niño conditions bite across Melanesia.

PALAU · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Palau upgrades Koror fire hydrant network ahead of El Niño

Fire safety and emergency response capacity in the State of Koror, which holds about 64 percent of Palau's population, has been boosted through a fire hydrant network upgrade as El Niño approaches. Palau takes the Pacific Islands Forum chair this cycle under President Surangel Whipps Jr.

SAMOA · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Samoa puts money into climate science capacity

Samoa is investing in scientific capacity to measure climate impacts already unfolding across the Pacific, on the argument that understanding change begins with understanding its effects. The push parallels regional calls this week to base adaptation spending on local data.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Marape and Rosso mark 51 years of independence with calls for discipline

In his 51st Independence message, Prime Minister **James Marape** said national development also required discipline and respect for others. Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Lands, Physical Planning and

Urbanisation **John Rosso** urged Papua New Guineans to reset their mindset toward development as the country enters its next fifty years. The anniversary closes PNG's Golden Jubilee year.

• NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Coalition partners turn on National over supermarket break-up plan

National announced a plan to sever Pak'nSave from New World, contingent on a six-month Commerce Commission review, and its coalition partners attacked it. **Winston Peters** played reporters "The Great Pretender" on his phone, said National had "cut and pasted" NZ First's April policy and that the move came "far too late" to pass this term; ACT called it "desperate and visionless." **Christopher Luxon** said he was pleased National had found political consensus with NZ First.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

New Zealand sovereign wealth fund returns 14.2 percent

New Zealand's sovereign wealth fund returned *14.2 percent*, which Bloomberg describes as world-beating. The result lands in the campaign period before the November 7 election, with fiscal management contested between the coalition and the opposition.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

El Niño threatens a profit squeeze for New Zealand dairy farmers

New Zealand dairy farmers face a profit squeeze as El Niño looms, Bloomberg reports. The same climate driver is already destroying crops in Papua New Guinea's highlands, giving Wellington a domestic economic stake in an event now framed regionally as a food security problem.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

FIJI · INFRASTRUCTURE · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Guangdong provincial government to expand solar lighting across Fiji

More Fijian communities are expected to gain better-lit public spaces after the Government of Guangdong Province backed an expansion of solar lighting. Provincial-level Chinese government funding of small community infrastructure remains a recurring channel of PRC engagement in Fiji.

REGIONAL · DIPLOMATIC CONTEST · ISLANDS BUSINESS

US backs Taiwan's continued role at the Pacific Islands Forum

PACNEWS reports the United States backing Taiwan's continued role in the Pacific Islands Forum and warning of China's "malign activities" in the region. Taiwan was excluded from the 2025 Leaders Meeting in Solomon Islands and reported as attending in 2026; the Marshall Islands, Palau and Tuvalu are the three Forum members with formal ties to Taipei.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

ABC POLITICS

Labor encouraged council to seek millions in grants process

Labor encouraged a council to request millions of dollars through a grants process, according to ABC reporting on a \$5 million pledge in Health Minister **Mark Butler**'s seat. The government faces questions over whether the

process amounted to pork-barrelling.

THE AUSTRALIAN

Bowen faces a reality check on climate targets before COP

Chris Bowen is confronting a gutted green goal as COP preparations advance, The Australian reports. Australia's COP31 ambitions carry a Pacific dimension, with Fiji set to host a Pacific pre-COP in Nadi.

THE AUSTRALIAN

Refugee intake pledge opens a \$7bn hole in Labor's budget

Anthony Albanese's pledge not to touch the refugee intake blows a *\$7 billion* hole through Labor's budget, The Australian reports. The figure lands the same day the government moved to curb family visas for international students.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Traders price in three more RBA increases

Traders and strategists say there is an increasing probability the Reserve Bank goes harder than expected, with three further increases now in view and recession risk rising. The cash rate has been held at 4.35 percent at each of the past two meetings. The ASX 200 closed at 8,696, down 2.41 percent, and the Australian dollar bought 0.7132 US cents, down 1.23 percent.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

New-home sales fall as builders warn of more rate pain

New-home sales are in free fall on budget and interest rate rise fears, with builders warning of further pain. Housing and rates dominated exchanges between the major parties today, each claiming to be better placed to resolve them.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Anthropic signs its first Australian data centre lease

Anthropic has signed a data centre deal in Queensland, its first Australian facility. The AFR reported the lease alongside market commentary that the biggest fear among investors is no longer an AI bubble.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Latrobe Magnesium plant heads to the US instead of Victoria

A *\$1.5 billion* Latrobe Magnesium manufacturing project went to the United States rather than Victoria, which The Australian attributes to state red tape. Magnesium sits on critical minerals lists that Washington and Canberra are trying to build joint supply chains around.

• UPCOMING

SEP
17

PNG's new firearms penalties take effect, with illegal possession punishable by life imprisonment

Enforcement begins with far fewer weapons surrendered than provincial officials expected, ahead of next year's national election.

SEP
2026

Commerce Commission review of the New Zealand supermarket duopoly, on which National's break-up plan is contingent

Peters says the timetable puts any structural separation beyond this parliamentary term.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Coalition partners are already campaigning against one another on grocery prices and policy authorship.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, including Winston Peters' tenure as foreign minister.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Four years on: what has happened to ending enforced family separation under PALM

Stephen Howes asks why the government is still dragging its feet four years after Labor promised to end forced family separation under the PALM scheme. The question lands the same day ABC's Wantok reported the death of an Enga seasonal worker at Shepparton in Victoria, with a fellow seasonal worker accused over it.

ABC PACIFIC

Enga seasonal worker dies in Shepparton, Victoria

A Papua New Guinean seasonal worker died at Shepparton in Victoria and the man accused of causing the death is in police custody. **Jeremiah Yambi**, president of the Shepparton PNG community and himself a seasonal worker, said the dispute involved two workers from Wabag district in Enga province and that the matter is now with Australian police and courts.

AU-POLITICS

ASPI STRATEGIST

Australians should be able to choose the algorithms they trust

The piece argues that if Australia regulates social media algorithms it should first be precise about what an algorithm is, faulting the terms of the digital duty of care debate.

TRADE-ECONOMY

NEW YORK TIMES

How electric cars took hold in Australia

The New York Times examines the rise of electric vehicles in Australia against war-driven fuel prices. Brent crude traded at 107.63, up 2.89 percent.

• ANALYSIS AND OPINION

ASPI STRATEGIST

How Australia can execute its denial strategy long before SSNs arrive

The piece argues the capability gap between now and the 2040s is the strategy's central problem and proposes filling it with other means during the 2030s.

Argument: Australia must make its declared strategy of denial effective in the 2030s, well before nuclear submarines become meaningfully capable in the 2040s.

LOWY INTERPRETER

Australia and the next UN chief need each other

The article makes the case for Australian investment in the succession at the United Nations, tying Canberra's multilateral history to its current interests.

Argument: Australia has both the record and the interest to back the next UN secretary-general as António Guterres' term ends amid crisis.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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